

Cognizant Assessment and Appraisal Policy

1. Overview

Performance assessments and appraisals at Cognizant are designed to foster continuous learning, measure competency, and reward excellence. The objective is to align individual goals with organizational objectives, provide constructive feedback, and determine career progression, compensation revisions, and training needs. The primary types of assessments include training assessments, probation reviews, and annual performance appraisals.

2. GenC Training Assessments (Freshers)

The GenC program ensures new graduates are project-ready.

- ****Assessments:**** Includes weekly quizzes, hands-on coding challenges, and mock project implementations.
- ****Minimum Passing Score:**** A consistent minimum score of 60% across all modules is mandatory.
- ****Reassessment Policy:**** If a trainee scores below 60%, a reassessment is scheduled within a week after remedial training.
- ****Consequences of Failing:**** Failing reassessments may lead to an extension of the training period or, in severe cases, termination of employment due to non-performance.
- ****Final Project Presentation:**** The training culminates in a final capstone project which is evaluated by technical SMEs.

3. Probation Assessment

Every new employee undergoes a probation period (6 months for freshers, 3 months for laterals).

- ****Mid-probation Review:**** At the 3-month mark (for freshers) or 45-day mark (for laterals), a preliminary review is conducted to provide early feedback.
- ****End-of-probation Review:**** A comprehensive review evaluating technical skills, communication, teamwork, adherence to policies, and attendance.

- ****Outcome:**** Successful evaluation leads to employment confirmation. If performance is sub-par, probation may be extended by 3 months, or employment may be terminated.

4. Annual Performance Appraisal

The annual appraisal cycle runs from April 1st to March 31st of the following year.

- ****Goal Setting:**** Employees must set SMART (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound) goals in the performance management system by April 30th.
- ****Mid-year Review:**** Conducted in October to track progress, recalibrate goals if necessary, and address any performance gaps.
- ****Year-end Review:**** In March, employees complete a self-assessment, highlighting achievements against their goals.
- ****Manager Assessment:**** Managers evaluate the self-assessment, gather feedback, and propose a final rating.

5. Rating System

Cognizant utilizes a 5-point rating scale for the annual appraisal:

- ****1 - Unsatisfactory:**** Fails to meet basic expectations; significant performance issues.
- ****2 - Needs Improvement:**** Meets some expectations but falls short in critical areas. Needs targeted development.
- ****3 - Meets Expectations:**** Consistently delivers on all goals and job requirements.
- ****4 - Exceeds Expectations:**** Often goes above and beyond, delivering high-quality work and taking extra initiatives.
- ****5 - Outstanding:**** Exceptional performance, significant business impact, and demonstrates leadership qualities.

****Bell Curve:**** Ratings are normalized across business units using a bell curve distribution to ensure fairness and budgetary compliance.

6. Promotion Criteria

Promotions at Cognizant are based on merit, business needs, and readiness for the next level.

- **Minimum Tenure:** Generally requires 18-24 months in the current role, though exceptions exist for outstanding performers.
- **Consistent High Ratings:** Typically requires ratings of 4 or 5 in consecutive cycles.
- **Skill Certifications:** Completion of mandatory role-based certifications on Cognizant Academy.
- **Leadership Competencies:** Demonstrated ability to handle the responsibilities of the next level.
- **Promotion Bands:** Analyst → Programmer Analyst → Associate → Senior Associate → Manager → Senior Manager → AVP → VP.

7. Continuous Feedback (Check-ins)

Performance management is not just a once-a-year event.

- **Quarterly Check-ins:** Managers and reportees should have documented quarterly check-ins.
- **360-Degree Feedback:** For Manager levels and above, feedback is collected from peers, subordinates, and stakeholders.
- **Peer Reviews:** Agile teams frequently utilize peer reviews to assess teamwork and code quality.

8. Performance Improvement Plan (PIP)

Employees receiving a rating of '1' or consistently poor feedback are placed on a PIP.

- **Duration:** Typically 60 to 90 days.
- **Milestones:** Clear, measurable, and weekly/bi-weekly milestones are established.
- **Support:** Mentorship and additional training are provided.
- **Consequences:** Successful completion returns the employee to standard status. Failure to meet PIP objectives results in separation from the company.

9. Skill Assessments and Certifications

- ****Technical Skill Assessments:**** Periodic mandatory assessments to ensure skills remain relevant to market demands.
- ****Role-based Certifications:**** Required for career progression (e.g., Cloud Architect certification for Senior Associates aiming for Manager).
- ****Impact on Appraisal:**** Proactive upskilling and obtaining certifications positively influence the performance rating and promotion readiness.

10. Compensation Review

- ****Annual Salary Revision:**** Effective typically from July, revisions are directly linked to the performance rating (3, 4, or 5).
- ****Variable Pay / Bonus:**** Disbursed annually or semi-annually, dependent on individual performance rating and overall company performance.
- ****Salary Bands:**** Raises are also calibrated based on where the employee's current salary sits within the industry-benchmarked salary band for their role.

11. FAQs

****Q1: How do I appeal my appraisal rating if I disagree?****

A: You can initiate a discussion with your manager. If unresolved, you may escalate to the HR Business Partner (HRBP) within 15 days of the rating release.

****Q2: Am I eligible for a bonus if I am serving my notice period?****

A: Employees serving a notice period on the day of bonus disbursement are generally not eligible, as per the standard policy.

****Q3: Does taking long leave impact my appraisal?****

A: Pro-rated goals are considered for approved long leaves (like maternity leave). However, a minimum number of active working days (usually 180 days) is required to be eligible for the annual cycle.

****Q4: Can I get promoted during probation?****

A: No, you must be a confirmed employee to be eligible for a promotion.

****Q5: What happens if I miss the goal-setting deadline?****

A: Missing deadlines may reflect poorly on compliance and could negatively impact your final rating.

****Q6: Is variable pay guaranteed?****

A: No, variable pay is contingent upon company performance metrics and your individual rating.

****Q7: Can lateral hires participate in the appraisal cycle in their first year?****

A: Yes, provided they have joined before the cut-off date (usually September 30th) to have sufficient time to be evaluated.

****Q8: Where can I check my current salary band?****

A: Salary bands are internal to HR and Management; however, compensation discussions with your manager will clarify your market positioning.